

## Windows Emulation

Well, most users would not want to stick to Linux as their main operating system. There are several alternatives that have been taken into consideration in Linux itself. There are emulators such as Wine (Windows emulator), which allows you to run Windows-based applications on the Linux platform itself. All you have to do is mount your Windows partition and specify the path of your Windows system directory. After that you can simply start up most Windows-based applications on the system. Colours and settings are picked up by Wine itself and you have almost the same look generated by the emulator.

Apart from emulation, other alternatives are also available. These require more CPU power and RAM. Besides,

unlike Wine, these software aren't free. VMWare is one such software that allows you to boot another operating system from a standalone operating system.

Wine might give emulation for most programs, but VMWare gives you quality working conditions. However, its system requirements are quite high.

Some work has also been happening the other way round, running Linux through Windows. One example is Win Linux, which is a Linux distribution running through Windows. Even the installation for Win Linux is through Windows.

There are emulators for other operating systems as well, such as DOSEmu, which emulates DOS. WinLinux is a distribution that installs on the Windows partition and can be run through itself.

Both these distributions also give a DVD—a big help for those who have a DVD drive as it saves you the trouble of inserting CD after CD during the installation.

Some of the main applications that come bundled with SuSE are the Star Office 5.2 suite, CryptoFS and Amavis, which is a virus-proof e-mail system. The normal installation puts Star Office into your hard drive. However, you need to manually initialise the installation of the office suite after the installation.

RedHat isn't too far behind either. Similar packages are given in the CDs. The normal install size comes to around 1.3 GB in the case of RedHat. The install size for SuSE, RedHat and Mandrake usually comes to around 1 GB, which includes a sufficient number of applications that

would be required by a home user, thus eliminating the need for the other extra CDs.

Mandrake didn't come with any extra CDs or manuals. We only received two main installation CDs, and that too in the form of a 'burnt CD' distribution, custom made as if burning on to a CD-R. Mandrake installs KOffice for the office users.

### And some features

Standalone features are small features that are very useful while using Linux, but which don't quite fit into a particular category. These may be small tools and packages created by a distribution for configuration of hardware or for other reasons.

One interesting tool that Storm Linux comes along with is SAS, which is a user-

and group-management tool. The installation file format is based on DPKG (Debian's package format)

Linux Mandrake has its own user management tool, Userdrake. Mandrake comes packed with a whole lot of applications for the Internet. There are messengers and browsers, which people working on the Net will find useful. The rest of the distributions use most of the tools that come along with KDE or Gnome for configuring the system.

Linuxconf, a configuration tool for hardware and other components such as daemons (programs required to start during boot up as they are the main base for other applications to run) and boot loaders, is also widely used in most of the distributions. In RedHat, however, we had trouble starting up Linuxconf.

The default file installation format is usually .RPM and .DEB, which are default formats in RedHat and Debian. GnoRPM is usually found in distributions for the installation of RPM files.

### Vote for value

The distributions today can all be downloaded from the Net. However, there's more than simply the installation itself in the whole distribution. A majority of the distributions come with extra manuals and CDs that sometimes have commercial software.

RedHat came with the maximum number of CDs. It comes with a lot of demos and also a lot of commercial packages. It has Star Office 5.2, a complete Power tools CD with a huge number of applications. Adobe Acrobat and messaging tools for the Internet are also available. The price for these packages is, however, quite a lot and therefore it is suitable only for professionals.

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